

Constipation in Children

Dietary & Lifestyle Guide for Parents

1. How Much Fibre Does My Child Need?

Child's Age	Daily Fibre Target
2 years	7 g / day
3 years	8 g / day
5 years	10 g / day
8 years	13 g / day
10 years	15 g / day
12 years	17 g / day

2. Foods to Include (High Fibre + Bowel-Friendly)

Category	Best Foods
Green Leafy Vegetables	Spinach, drumstick leaves, amaranth (mulai keerai)
Other Vegetables	Carrot, beans, sweet potato, cucumber (raw), broccoli, drumstick
Fruits	Papaya, guava, pear, apple (with skin), prunes, figs (anjeer), dates
Whole Grains	Ragi, whole wheat roti, oats, brown rice, kambu (bajra), millets
Legumes / Dal	All dals, rajma, chickpeas, green peas, horse gram
Fermented Foods	Curd, buttermilk, idli, dosa, probiotic yoghurt

3. Offer Water Frequently — Every Single Day

Water softens the stool. Without enough water, even a high-fibre diet will not work.

Age	Minimum Water / Fluids per Day	Best Fluid Choices
1 – 3 yrs	1.0 – 1.3 L	Water, coconut water, buttermilk
4 – 8 yrs	1.5 L	Water, prune juice, dal water
9 – 13 yrs	1.7 – 2.1 L	Water, coconut water, chaas
Teens	2.0 – 2.5 L	Water — avoid cold drinks & tea

4. Foods to Limit

- Maida (refined flour)
- Excess polished white rice
- Unripe banana
- Cheese in large quantity
- Junk food / chips / fried items
- Cold drinks / carbonated beverages
- Excess tea / coffee (older children)

5. Lifestyle Measures

Measure	What to Do
Physical Activity	Minimum 1 hour outdoor play daily — activity directly stimulates bowel movement
Toilet Routine	Let the child sit on the toilet for 10 to 15 minutes at the same time every day
Proper Posture	Keep a small stool under the feet while on toilet — squatting position is ideal
No Pressure	Never scold or rush the child; use a reward chart for sitting on the toilet
Screen Time	Reduce — sedentary sitting worsens constipation

Daily Checklist for Parents

- ■ Give papaya or guava every day
- ■ Offer a glass of water every 1–2 hours
- ■ Add green leafy vegetable to at least ONE meal
- ■ Include ragi/whole wheat instead of maida
- ■ 1 hour outdoor play

Allergy Note: Always avoid any food listed above if your child is known to be allergic or sensitive to it.

Fibre Content by Food Portion — Quick Visual Guide

2 small fruits
100 g = 2 g
Fibre X 2 = 4 g



One tuber 100 g
= 4 g Fibre



One large Fruit
200 gm = 4 g
Fibre



50 gm GLV =
4 g Fibre



Green Leafy
vegetables will help

Use this as a quick reference to build up your child's daily fibre intake using everyday fruits, vegetables, and greens.